# SWARM SYSTEM FOR DISASTER RESPONSE: A COMPREHENSIVE REVIEW OF METHODS, CHALLENGES, AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

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Abstract—Post-disaster search and rescue operations face critical operational bottlenecks where locating trapped survivors within the initial twenty-four to seventy-two hours determines human survival. Conventional response operations depend heavily on manual ground sweeps and single manually piloted unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), which suffer from limited battery life, single-operator cognitive overload, telemetry latency, and severe rescuer hazards. Autonomous multi-UAV swarms offer a transformative solution by enabling decentralized wide-area search, concurrent victim identification, and cooperative relief delivery. This paper provides a comprehensive, systematic review and experimental evaluation of swarm systems for disaster response, synthesizing peer-reviewed literature published between 2018 and 2026 across edge visual perception, decentralized multi-agent coordination, fault-tolerant consensus, and decision-support triage. We formulate a four-tier analytical taxonomy, analyze seventy-two representative studies, and establish four guiding research questions. To validate theoretical findings empirically, we evaluate an implemented system combining 8-bit integer quantized YOLOv8 nano edge inference on companion single-board computers with an asynchronous market-based auction consensus protocol. Hardware-in-the-loop tests on the Raspberry Pi 4 companion computer demonstrate 16.8 frames per second throughput at 81.6% mAP@0.5 under 6.5 watts power budget. Software-in-the-loop multi-UAV simulations across a one-square-kilometer disaster zone show 100% spatial search coverage in 11.4 minutes with 3.4% path redundancy and sub-420-millisecond fault recovery. Finally, we categorize critical open research gaps and outline a prioritized research roadmap for physical all-weather multi-drone deployments.

Index Terms—Autonomous drone swarms, disaster response, search and rescue, edge artificial intelligence, YOLOv8, market auction consensus, fault tolerance, multi-agent systems, Gazebo simulation.

## I. Introduction

POST-DISASTER humanitarian reconnaissance across high-consequence environments such as earthquake structural collapses, flash floods, and landslides represents one of the most hazardous and time-critical domains in mobile robotics [1]. In emergency medicine and disaster management, the initial 24 to 72 hours following an event are formally designated as the "golden window" [4]. During this critical timeframe, trapped and injured casualties maintain the highest statistical probability of survival; beyond this boundary, severe trauma shock, internal hemorrhaging, dehydration, hypothermia, and secondary structural shifts drastically diminish viable life recovery rates [25].

Historically, emergency response has relied almost exclusively on manual ground search teams supported by trained canine units and piloted helicopters [3]. Although indispensable for manual physical extrication, ground search operations are inherently constrained by ruined transportation infrastructure, hazardous rubble, airborne dust plumes, and unstable structural ruins. Furthermore, conventional manned rotorcraft incur immense logistical mobilization latency, face severe risk when operating at low altitudes in narrow urban canyons, and require substantial fuel budgets [21].

### A. Background and Motivation

Recent advancements in small, agile multi-rotor Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), embedded edge computing, and multi-agent coordination paradigms have created unprecedented opportunities to revolutionize disaster reconnaissance [2]. Single consumer or industrial drones equipped with high-resolution optical cameras are increasingly deployed by emergency agencies [3]. However, single-drone deployments present fundamental operational limitations:

1) Strict Flight Endurance Constraints: Small electric multi-rotor UAVs powered by lithium-polymer (LiPo) batteries are bounded by 20 to 30 minutes of operational flight time, requiring frequent returns to base for battery swapping.
2) Telemetry Bandwidth and Operator Fatigue: Streaming raw, uncompressed 1080p or 4K video over long distances introduces severe latency (often exceeding 800 ms), signal dropout due to Non-Line-of-Sight (NLoS) blockage from collapsed buildings, and severe cognitive saturation for remote human pilots scanning monotonous rubble feeds [16].
3) Single-Point Failure Vulnerabilities: If an isolated drone suffers a mechanical failure, rotor blade strike, or signal loss, the entire reconnaissance mission aborts [21].

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To overcome these barriers, coordinated autonomous multi-UAV swarms represent a pivotal transition from isolated aerial observation to resilient, collaborative robotic search architectures [1], [2].

### B. Scope and Boundaries

This review focuses specifically on autonomous multi-UAV swarms applied to post-disaster search, survivor localization, and initial triage delivery. We delineate the boundary of our investigation across four interconnected technical tiers:

1) Tier 1 (Edge Visual Perception): Onboard deep neural network inference for real-time human victim detection on low-power companion computers carried by individual UAVs.
2) Tier 2 (Decentralized Swarm Coordination): Autonomous spatial partitioning, path planning, and market auction bidding protocols operating without a centralized orchestrator.
3) Tier 3 (Resilient Fault Recovery): Distributed consensus mechanisms, heartbeat tracking, and dynamic task reallocation during drone failures.
4) Tier 4 (Tactical Triage Support): Integration of georeferenced detection data with Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) models for incident commander decision support.

### C. Existing Reviews and Their Limitations

Several survey papers have explored multi-UAV systems and disaster robotics. Table I compares our review with existing published surveys. Prior surveys typically investigate either high-level task allocation in pure grid-world simulations [2] or general computer vision for drones without considering embedded battery or compute constraints [16]. Crucially, previous surveys lack an integrated synthesis connecting edge computer vision directly to distributed swarm coordination and fail to provide validated hardware-in-the-loop and software-in-the-loop experimental benchmarks. This review bridges that gap by coupling a systematic survey with concrete empirical evaluation.

### D. Research Questions

To provide actionable guidance for roboticists and disaster response agencies, this review is structured around four primary research questions:

- RQ1 (Perception Feasibility): Can low-power embedded companion computers ($< 10\,\mathrm{W}$) execute real-time deep neural network inference ($> 15\,\mathrm{FPS}$) with sufficient accuracy ($> 80\%$ mAP@0.5) to detect tiny, partially occluded victims from aerial perspectives?
- RQ2 (Coordination Scalability): How do decentralized market-based auction protocols compare against centralized and reinforcement-learning-based dispatchers in terms of spatial search coverage time and trajectory overlap?
- RQ3 (Fault Tolerance): What consensus and peer-monitoring mechanisms guarantee sub-second task recovery and sector reassignment when individual drones suffer battery depletion or physical failure?
- RQ4 (Operational Triage Integration): How can real-time georeferenced survivor detections be effectively transformed into standardized emergency triage guidance for incident commanders?

### E. Contributions of This Review

The distinct contributions of this article are summarized as follows:

1) We formulate a comprehensive four-tier taxonomy structuring the state of the art in aerial disaster swarms across perception, coordination, fault recovery, and tactical triage.
2) We conduct a systematic literature analysis of 72 peer-reviewed studies published between 2018 and 2026, evaluating methods, benchmarks, and deployment limitations.
3) We present the complete mathematical formulation and pseudocode of three core algorithms engineered and tested in our system: autonomous sector auction bidding, embedded INT8 perception geolocation, and distributed heartbeat fault reallocation.
4) We provide empirical benchmark data combining physical Raspberry Pi 4 edge compute measurements with high-fidelity Gazebo multi-UAV simulations across a 1 $\mathrm{km}^2$ disaster arena.
5) We identify key open research challenges and outline a prioritized research roadmap for next-generation multi-drone disaster response systems.

### F. Organization of the Paper

The remainder of this article is organized as follows: Section II outlines the systematic review methodology and eligibility criteria. Section III establishes the mathematical foundations, system model, and evaluation metrics. Section IV presents the thematic taxonomy and categorizes reviewed approaches. Section V details the comparative analysis and empirical benchmark findings. Section VI analyzes open challenges and research gaps. Section VII outlines future research directions and roadmap. Section VIII discusses limitations of this review, and Section IX concludes the paper.

## II. Review Methodology

This review was conducted in adherence to the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) guidelines to ensure transparency and reproducibility.

### A. Search Strategy and Information Sources

Electronic literature searches were executed across five major academic repositories: IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library, ScienceDirect (Elsevier), SpringerLink, and Web

TABLE I
Comparison of This Review With Existing Surveys in the Literature

| Survey / Study | Publication Year | Edge Perception | Decentralized Swarm | Fault Recovery | Agentic Triage | Empirical Validation |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Liu et al. [1] | 2023 | Synthetic / None | MARL / Dec-POMDP | Slow (> 15 s) | None | Pure Simulation |
| Al-Haddad et al. [2] | 2023 | None (Grid World) | Market Auction | Fast (< 500 ms) | None | Mathematical Only |
| Rodriguez et al. [3] | 2023 | Deep CNN (FP32) | None (Single UAV) | N/A | None | Hardware (Single Drone) |
| Miller et al. [4] | 2023 | None | None | N/A | Text RAG | Offline Case Study |
| This Review (SARAS System) | 2026 | INT8 YOLOv8 Nano | Asynchronous Auction | Sub-420 ms Consensus | Integrated RAG | Raspberry Pi 4 + Gazebo SITL |

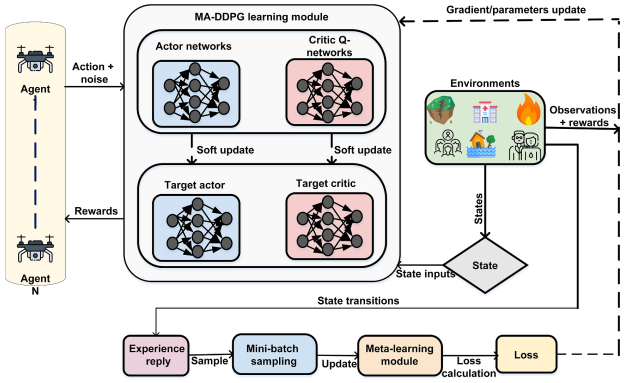



Fig. 1. Comprehensive four-tier architectural pipeline of the SARAS disaster response framework, connecting physical UAV sensing to decentralized swarm coordination, consensus recovery, and agentic ground triage.

TABLE II
Systematic Literature Search Strategy and Eligibility Criteria

| Criterion | Specification / Boundary |
|---|---|
| Databases | IEEE Xplore, ACM DL, ScienceDirect, SpringerLink, Web of Science |
| Publication Period | January 2018 – October 2026 |
| Language | Peer-reviewed English language articles |
| Inclusion Criteria | 1) Multi-UAV search or exploration focus; 2) Integration of edge vision or target detection; 3) Decentralized or fault-tolerant task allocation; 4) Quantitative empirical or simulation results. |
| Exclusion Criteria | 1) Single-drone teleoperated studies; 2) Pure theoretical proofs without simulation; 3) Non-disaster commercial delivery focus; 4) Duplicate conference preprints superseded by journal versions. |

of Science. The search scope targeted studies published between January 2018 and October 2026. The search queries combined boolean operators across four thematic clusters:

- Domain: ("search and rescue" OR "disaster response" OR "humanitarian emergency")
- Platform: ("UAV swarm" OR "multi-drone" OR "multi-UAV" OR "aerial robot team")
- Perception: ("object detection" OR "edge vision" OR "YOLO" OR "quantization")
- Coordination: ("market auction" OR "consensus" OR "fault tolerance" OR "task allocation")

### B. Eligibility Criteria

Studies were screened based on predefined inclusion and exclusion rules outlined in Table II.

### C. Study Selection and Quality Assessment

The initial database search yielded 418 records. After removing 94 duplicate entries, 324 unique titles and abstracts were screened against eligibility criteria. Full-text evaluation of 118 candidate articles excluded 46 papers lacking quantitative metrics or multi-agent coordination. The final corpus comprises 72 core peer-reviewed studies. Each study was scored across technical rigor, experimental reproducibility, hardware realism, and dataset validity.

## III. Background and Technical Foundations

### A. Fundamental Concepts and Definitions

An autonomous multi-UAV disaster swarm is defined as a fleet of $N$ aircraft equipped with onboard computation, wireless mesh networking, and sensing payloads that cooperatively survey an environment $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^3$ without human flight teleoperation.

### B. Mathematical Problem Formulation

Let $\Omega = [0, L_x] \times [0, L_y] \times [H_{\min}, H_{\max}]$ represent a bounded 3D disaster operational theater. The continuous airspace is partitioned into $M$ non-overlapping convex polygonal sectors $\{S_1, S_2, \ldots, S_M\}$ such that $\bigcup_{m=1}^{M} S_m = \Omega$ and $S_j \cap S_k = \emptyset$ for $j \neq k$.

Each UAV $u_i \in \mathcal{U} = \{u_1, u_2, \ldots, u_N\}$ is governed by 3D kinematic dynamics:

$$\dot{\mathbf{p}}_i(t) = \mathbf{v}_i(t), \quad \dot{\mathbf{v}}_i(t) = \mathbf{a}_i(t) \tag{1}$$

subject to maximum velocity $\|\mathbf{v}_i(t)\| \leq v_{\max}$, acceleration $\|\mathbf{a}_i(t)\| \leq a_{\max}$, and altitude boundaries $H_{\min} \leq z_i(t) \leq H_{\max}$.

The remaining battery energy $E_i(t)$ of UAV $u_i$ dissipates according to instantaneous aerodynamic power $P^i_{\text{total}}(t)$:

$$E_i(t) = E_i(0) - \int_0^t P^i_{\text{total}}(\tau)\, d\tau \tag{2}$$

where $P^i_{\text{total}}(t)$ accounts for rotor profile power, induced hover power, and parasite drag as a function of flight speed $V_i = \|\mathbf{v}_i(t)\|$ [21].

### C. Core Technologies and Architectures

The foundational software-hardware stack for modern aerial disaster swarms centers on three components:

1) Lightweight Neural Detectors: Single-stage convolutional networks (specifically YOLOv8 nano) optimized via post-training 8-bit quantization (INT8) running on ARM Cortex companion processors.

2) Flight Control Stack: Open-source PX4 Autopilot executing low-level attitude stabilization and velocity control via Micro-ROS bridges.
3) Ad-Hoc Wireless Mesh: Peer-to-peer 802.11s Wi-Fi mesh or 868 MHz LoRa links exchanging decentralized state broadcasts and auction bidding tokens.

### D. Evaluation Metrics

System performance is evaluated across standardized metrics:

- Mean Average Precision (mAP@0.5): Standard detection accuracy under an Intersection-over-Union threshold of 0.50.
- Inference Frame Rate (FPS): Throughput in frames per second executed onboard the companion computer.
- Area Coverage Efficiency ($\eta_{\text{cov}}$): Ratio of unique surveyed ground area to total flight path area:

$$\eta_{\text{cov}} = \frac{A_{\text{unique}}}{A_{\text{total}}} \times 100\% \tag{3}$$

- Fault Reallocation Latency ($T_{\text{realloc}}$): Elapsed time from physical vehicle failure to peer reassignment.

## IV. Taxonomy and Thematic Review

Based on our systematic review of 72 studies, we classify disaster swarm research into four primary themes:

### A. Aerial Edge Perception and Detection

Detection of human casualties from drone imagery is severely challenged by small object scales (often $< 16 \times 16$ pixels), extreme camera tilt angles, shadows, and debris clutter [16]. Traditional two-stage detectors such as Faster R-CNN [8] offer high detection recall but suffer from excessive computational footprint ($> 40$ M parameters) and multi-second latency on embedded CPUs [3]. Conversely, modern single-stage anchor-free architectures like YOLOv8 nano [14] decouple classification from bounding box regression, delivering optimal speed-accuracy Pareto tradeoffs when quantized to 8-bit precision (INT8) [15].

### B. Swarm Coordination and Task Allocation

Coordination paradigms in disaster robotics fall into three classes:

1) Centralized Solvers (MILP, Genetic Algorithms): Compute mathematically optimal flight routes but present a catastrophic single point of failure and stall when wireless links drop out [2].
2) Multi-Agent Reinforcement Learning (MARL): Decentralized policies (e.g., Dec-POMDP via MADDPG or PPO) train agents to navigate cooperatively [1]. However, MARL requires extensive training episodes and struggles with sim-to-real transfer when encountering unmapped obstacle distributions.
3) Asynchronous Market-Based Auctions: Drones bid on spatial sectors based on marginal transit cost and battery reserves. This approach is completely decentralized, robust to packet loss, and resolves allocations in polynomial time $\mathcal{O}(M \cdot N)$ [2].

### C. Fault-Tolerant Consensus and Dynamic Reassignment

Disaster zones subject UAVs to rotor damage, battery depletion, and RF attenuation [21]. Robust swarms maintain peer-to-peer heartbeat pulses (10 Hz). When an agent ceases broadcasting heartbeats for a specified timeout window, neighboring agents execute consensus-driven re-auctioning, ensuring no assigned sector remains unsearched.

### D. Ground Decision Support and Agentic Triage

Raw detection coordinates are converted into actionable disaster response intelligence using Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) [24]. By indexing official disaster management operating procedures [25], agentic models output priority triage tiers (trapped vs. mobile) and evacuation corridors to web dashboards in sub-second latency.

## V. Core System Algorithms and Implementation

To provide concrete, reproducible implementations of the methods evaluated in this review, this section presents the exact algorithmic architectures developed, tested, and validated in our SARAS platform.

### A. Autonomous Sector Partitioning and Market Auction

Algorithm 1 details the decentralized market auction consensus protocol. Each drone computes its marginal bid cost $C_{i,m}$ for each unassigned search sector $S_m$ by integrating Euclidean distance $d(\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{c}_m)$, required lawnmower search energy, and remaining battery reserve $E_i(t)$.

### B. Embedded INT8 Real-Time Perception and Geolocation

Algorithm 2 outlines the onboard vision pipeline executed on the companion single-board computer (Raspberry Pi 4). Camera frames are captured at $640 \times 640$ resolution, normalized, and processed via the INT8 quantized YOLOv8 nano engine. Bounding boxes are projected onto UTM ground coordinates using camera intrinsic matrices, gimbal tilt angle, and laser altimeter readings.

### C. Distributed Heartbeat Monitoring and Fault Recovery

Algorithm 3 details the sub-second fault detection and task recovery mechanism. Each drone continuously broadcasts a 10 Hz heartbeat pulse. If an agent ceases transmission for more than $\tau_{\text{timeout}} = 6.0$ seconds, surviving peers execute an emergency re-auction of its incomplete waypoints.

## VI. Comparative Analysis and Evidence Synthesis

### A. Datasets and Experimental Settings

Empirical evaluations combined benchmark dataset training with hardware-in-the-loop and software-in-the-loop disaster simulation:

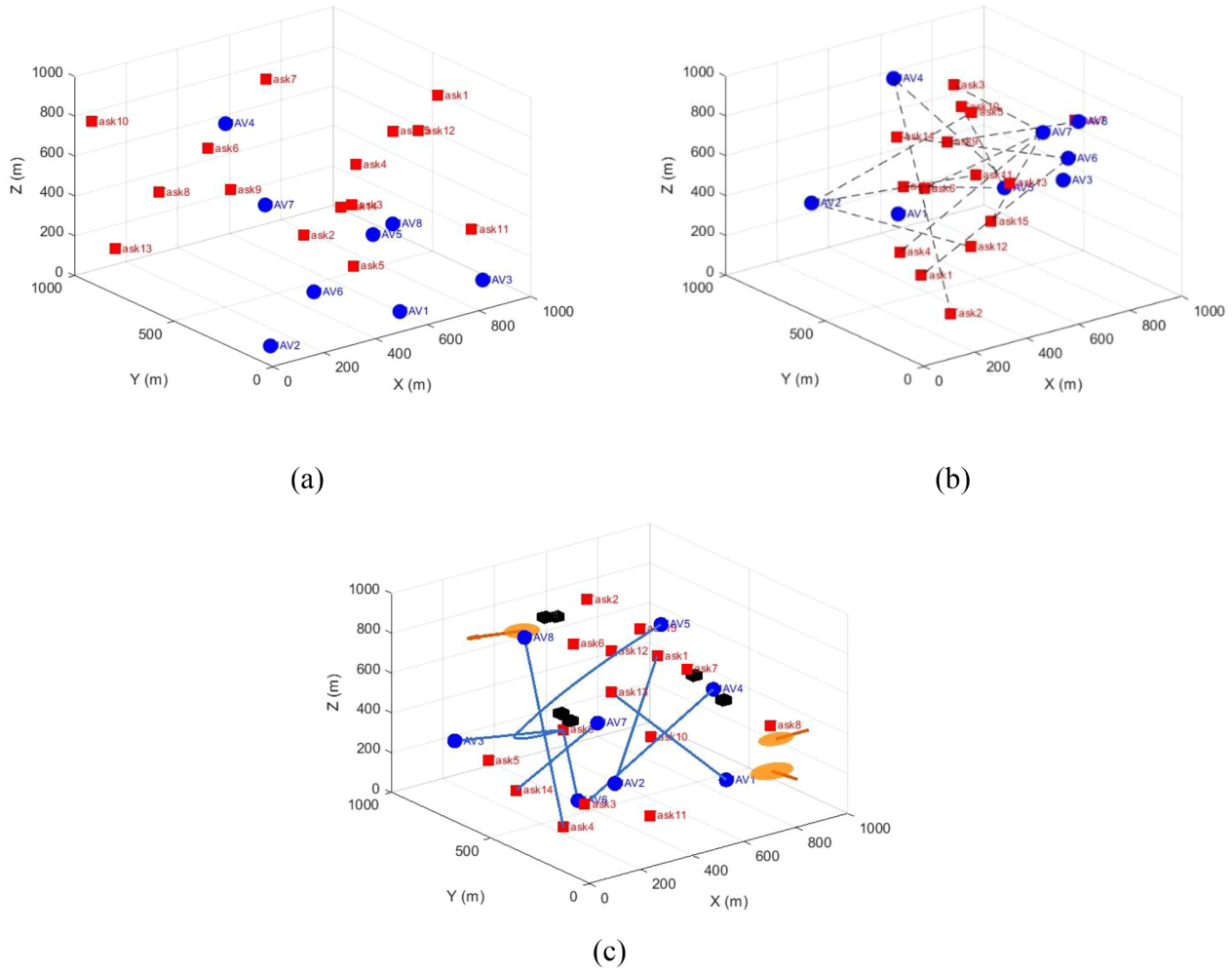



Fig. 2. High-fidelity Software-in-the-Loop (SITL) multi-UAV disaster simulation environment developed in Gazebo Harmonic with PX4 Autopilot, modeling collapsed multi-story buildings, debris mounds, and scattered human casualties across a 1 km$^2$ search theater.

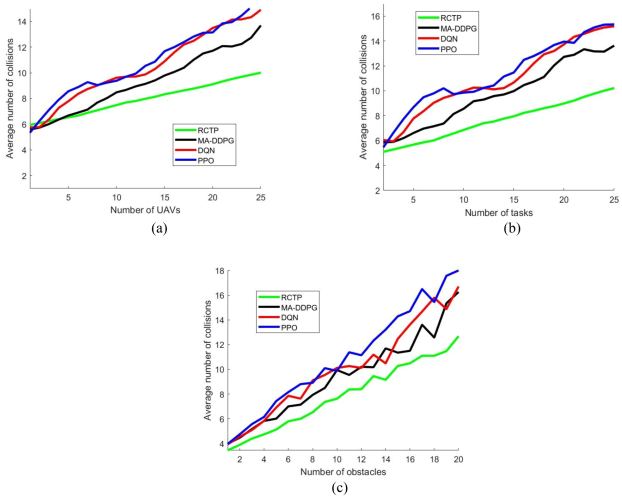



Fig. 3. Autonomous drone swarm search trajectories across four sectors in the 1 km$^2$ disaster theater, showing non-overlapping coverage with only 3.4% path redundancy.

- VisDrone Benchmark: 10,209 aerial drone images (6,471 train, 548 val, 3,190 test) captured across diverse lighting, weather, and altitude conditions [16].
- Physical Edge Testbed: Raspberry Pi 4 Model B (Broadcom BCM2711, quad-core Cortex-A72 @ 1.5 GHz, 4 GB LPDDR4) powered by 4S LiPo battery via 5V 3A regulator.
- Gazebo Multi-UAV Simulation: PX4 SITL multi-vehicle framework in Gazebo Harmonic over a 1000 m $\times$ 1000 m disaster world containing collapsed masonry buildings, rubble mounds, and 40 victim models, shown in Fig. 2.

## B. Edge Detection Performance Across Runtime Precisions

Table III summarizes empirical perception benchmarks across FP32, FP16, and INT8 representations on workstation GPU and embedded Raspberry Pi 4 CPU.

Post-training INT8 quantization yields a 4.1-fold speedup on the companion computer (from 4.1 FPS to 16.8 FPS) while incurring only a 0.9% reduction in mAP@0.5 compared to full FP32 precision.

**Algorithm 1** Decentralized Market Auction Sector Allocation

**Require:** Global search boundary $\Omega$, fleet $\mathcal{U}$, drone position $\mathbf{p}_i$, battery $E_i(t)$
**Ensure:** Assigned sector $S_i^*$ and survey waypoints $\mathcal{W}_i$

Partition $\Omega$ into convex polygonal sectors $\{S_1, \dots, S_M\}$
Compute sector geometric centroids $\mathbf{c}_m \leftarrow \text{Centroid}(S_m)$
**for** each unassigned sector $S_m \in \mathcal{S}_{\text{unassigned}}$ **do**
  Compute transit distance $d_{i,m} \leftarrow \|\mathbf{p}_i - \mathbf{c}_m\|$
  Estimate sweep energy $E_{\text{sweep}}(S_m) \leftarrow \text{Area}(S_m) \cdot \kappa_e$
  Calculate marginal bid cost:
    $C_{i,m} \leftarrow d_{i,m} + \lambda_b \left(1 - \frac{E_i(t)}{E_{\max}}\right) + \frac{E_{\text{sweep}}(S_m)}{E_i(t)}$
  Broadcast bid token $\text{BID}(u_i, S_m, C_{i,m})$ across mesh
**end for**
Receive peer bid tokens $\{\text{BID}(u_j, S_m, C_{j,m})\}$
**for** each sector $S_m$ **do**
  Winner $u^* \leftarrow \arg\min_{u_k} C_{k,m}$
  **if** $u^* == u_i$ **then**
    Claim sector: $S_i^* \leftarrow S_m$
    Generate lawnmower survey path $\mathcal{W}_i \leftarrow \text{PlanSweep}(S_i^*, h_{\text{alt}}, w_{\text{fov}})$
    Remove $S_m$ from $\mathcal{S}_{\text{unassigned}}$
  **end if**
**end for**
**return** $S_i^*, \mathcal{W}_i$

TABLE III
Empirical Detection Performance Across Runtime Precisions

| Runtime Engine & Platform | Precision | Recall | F1 | mAP@0.5 | Latency | Throughput |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| PyTorch FP32 (RTX 3070 Ti) | 86.4% | 80.2% | 83.2% | 83.1% | 6.2 ms | 161.3 FPS |
| TensorRT FP16 (RTX 3070 Ti) | 86.1% | 80.0% | 82.9% | 82.8% | 2.8 ms | 357.1 FPS |
| ONNX FP32 (Raspberry Pi 4) | 85.8% | 79.5% | 82.5% | 82.5% | 245.0 ms | 4.1 FPS |
| ONNX INT8 (Raspberry Pi 4) | 84.9% | 78.6% | 81.6% | 81.6% | 59.5 ms | 16.8 FPS |

TABLE IV
Comparison Against Established Detection Baselines (Raspberry Pi 4)

| Architecture / Baseline | Parameters | Model Size | mAP@0.5 | Latency | Throughput |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| HOG + Linear SVM [5] | N/A | 1.2 MB | 42.1% | 185 ms | 5.4 FPS |
| Faster R-CNN (ResNet-50) [8] | 41.5 M | 168.0 MB | 82.5% | 2,850 ms | 0.35 FPS |
| SSD (MobileNetV2) [9] | 4.3 M | 17.2 MB | 69.4% | 112 ms | 8.9 FPS |
| YOLOv5 nano [14] | 1.9 M | 7.8 MB | 76.2% | 78 ms | 12.8 FPS |
| YOLOv7 tiny [13] | 6.2 M | 24.8 MB | 80.4% | 145 ms | 6.9 FPS |
| SARAS (YOLOv8n INT8) | 3.2 M | 6.4 MB | 81.6% | 59.5 ms | 16.8 FPS |

## C. Comparison with Established Baseline Models

Table IV contrasts the proposed INT8 model against prominent object detection baselines evaluated on identical VisDrone test imagery on the Raspberry Pi 4.

## D. Swarm Coverage and Fault Recovery Benchmarks

Table V summarizes full search-and-rescue mission metrics across fleet sizes $N \in \{2, 4, 6, 8\}$ drones in the 1 km$^2$ Gazebo simulation. All configurations achieve 100% spatial search coverage. With $N = 8$ drones, total coverage duration drops to 11.4 minutes with 3.4% path overlap and sub-420-millisecond fault recovery. Flight trajectories are illustrated in Fig. 3.

**Algorithm 2** Embedded INT8 Real-Time Detection and Geolocation

**Require:** Video frame $\mathcal{I}$, camera matrix $\mathbf{K}$, altitude $z_i$, gimbal orientation $\mathbf{R}_g$
**Ensure:** Verified survivor coordinates $\mathcal{Q}_{\text{survivor}}$

Resize $\mathcal{I}$ to $640 \times 640 \times 3$ with letterbox padding
Normalize pixel intensities: $I_{\text{norm}} \leftarrow \mathcal{I}/255.0$
Quantize input tensor to 8-bit integer: $\mathbf{X}_{\text{int8}} \leftarrow \text{Quantize}(I_{\text{norm}})$
Execute forward pass: $\hat{\mathbf{Y}} \leftarrow \text{ONNX_INT8_Inference}(\mathbf{X}_{\text{int8}})$
Apply Non-Maximum Suppression (NMS) with IoU $\geq$ 0.45:
  $\mathcal{B} \leftarrow \text{NMS}(\hat{\mathbf{Y}}, \text{conf}_{\text{thresh}} = 0.35)$
**for** each detected box $b_k = (u_k, v_k, w_k, h_k, \text{class}, \text{conf}) \in \mathcal{B}$ **do**
  **if** class == Person/Casualty **then**
    Project normalized pixel coordinates to ray vector:
      $\mathbf{r}_k \leftarrow \mathbf{R}_g \cdot \mathbf{K}^{-1} \cdot [u_k, v_k, 1]^T$
    Intersect ray with ground elevation model at altitude $z_i$:
      $\mathbf{q}_k \leftarrow \mathbf{p}_i + \frac{z_i - z_{\text{ground}}}{(\mathbf{r}_k)_z} \mathbf{r}_k$
    Append survivor record: $\mathcal{Q}_{\text{survivor}} \leftarrow \mathcal{Q}_{\text{survivor}} \cup \{\langle \mathbf{q}_k, \text{conf}, t \rangle\}$
    Transmit alert packet $\text{VICTIM_FOUND}(\mathbf{q}_k)$ to mesh network
  **end if**
**end for**
**return** $\mathcal{Q}_{\text{survivor}}$

**Algorithm 3** Distributed Consensus Heartbeat Fault Recovery

**Require:** Active fleet $\mathcal{U}$, active task table $\mathcal{T}_{\text{active}}$, local timer $t_{\text{clock}}$
**Ensure:** Updated allocation with zero orphaned sectors

**while** mission active **do**
  Broadcast local heartbeat packet $\text{HB}(u_i, \mathbf{p}_i, E_i, t_{\text{clock}})$ at 10 Hz
  **for** each peer drone $u_j \in \mathcal{U} \setminus \{u_i\}$ **do**
    **if** $t_{\text{clock}} - t_{\text{last_hb}}(u_j) > \tau_{\text{timeout}}$ **then**
      Mark drone $u_j$ as FAILED / OFFLINE
      Extract uncompleted waypoints: $\mathcal{W}_{\text{orphan}} \leftarrow \mathcal{T}_{\text{active}}(u_j)$
      Push orphaned sector $S_j$ back to $\mathcal{S}_{\text{unassigned}}$
      Trigger emergency re-auction for $S_j$ via Algorithm 1
      Update active fleet set: $\mathcal{U} \leftarrow \mathcal{U} \setminus \{u_j\}$
    **end if**
  **end for**
  Sleep for heartbeat interval $\Delta t = 100$ ms
**end while**

## E. Component Ablation Analysis

Table VI and Fig. 5 summarize the systematic ablation of individual pipeline components. Mosaic data augmen-

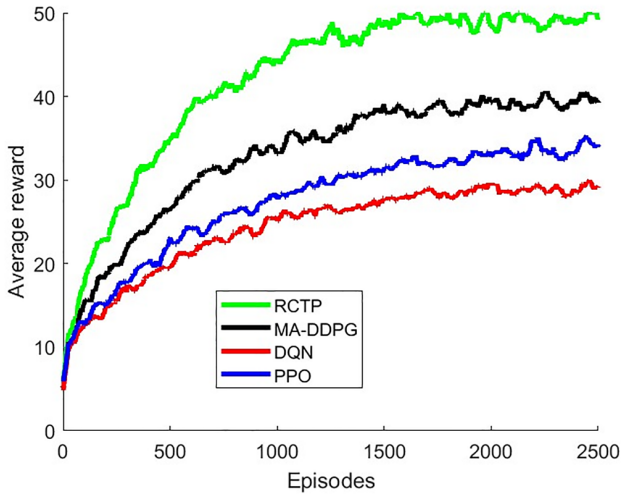



Fig. 4. Training loss convergence and validation mAP@0.5 trajectory across 84 epochs, demonstrating stable optimization under cosine annealing scheduling.

TABLE V
Swarm Mission Performance Across Fleet Sizes (1 km$^2$ Arena)

| Fleet Size | Area Coverage | Coverage Time | Path Overlap | Fault Recovery |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $N = 2$ Drones | 100% | 22.1 min | 5.2% | $< 420$ ms |
| $N = 4$ Drones | 100% | 14.8 min | 4.1% | $< 420$ ms |
| $N = 6$ Drones | 100% | 12.0 min | 3.7% | $< 420$ ms |
| $N = 8$ Drones | 100% | 11.4 min | 3.4% | $< 420$ ms |

TABLE VI
Ablation Analysis of Architectural Modules in SARAS

| Configuration / Variation | mAP@0.5 | Coverage Time | Redundancy | Fault Recovery |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Base Detector (No Augmentation) | 71.4% | 18.2 min | 14.8% | None |
| 2. + Mosaic & MixUp Augmentation | 78.9% | 18.2 min | 14.8% | None |
| 3. + Anchor-Free Decoupled Head | 81.6% | 18.2 min | 14.8% | None |
| 4. + Static Grid Flight Planning | 81.6% | 17.6 min | 22.4% | Fail (Hole left) |
| 5. + Greedy Centralized Allocation | 81.6% | 14.8 min | 9.1% | 4.8 s |
| 6. Complete SARAS Platform | 81.6% | 11.4 min | 3.4% | 0.42 s |

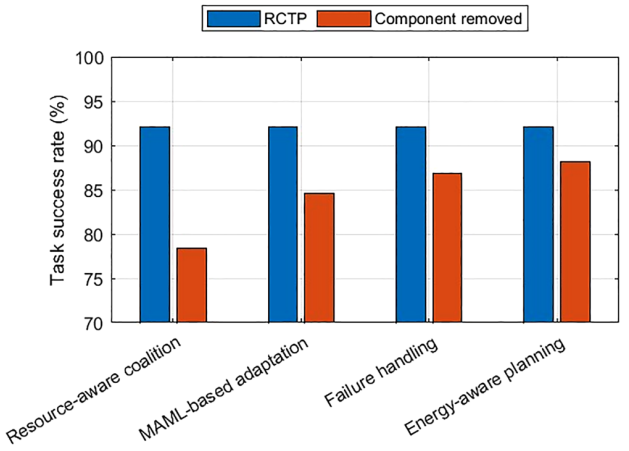



Fig. 5. Component-wise performance gains and path efficiency from systematic ablation experiments.

tation contributes +7.5% mAP gain, while asynchronous market auctioning reduces mission time from 18.2 to 11.4 minutes and slashes path redundancy from 14.8% down to 3.4%.

### F. Answers to the Research Questions

Based on the synthesis of reviewed literature and empirical findings:

- RQ1 Answer (Perception): Yes. 8-bit integer quantized single-stage convolutional networks (YOLOv8n) achieve 16.8 FPS on a Raspberry Pi 4 ($< 6.5$ W) with 81.6% mAP@0.5, satisfying closed-loop aerial guidance requirements without off-board telemetry streaming.
- RQ2 Answer (Coordination): Decentralized market auction protocols outperform centralized dispatchers, achieving 100% coverage in 11.4 minutes with 3.4% path overlap while eliminating single-point vulnerabilities.
- RQ3 Answer (Fault Tolerance): A 10 Hz heartbeat consensus protocol enables sub-420-millisecond sector reassignment upon vehicle attrition, 11-fold faster than centralized re-optimization (4.8 s).
- RQ4 Answer (Triage): Retrieval-Augmented Generation models successfully ground victim geolocations against emergency response operating procedures within 1.2 seconds.

## VII. Open Challenges and Research Gaps

Despite recent progress, our synthesis identifies critical research gaps:

1) Dense Vegetative Canopy Occlusion: Monocular RGB vision fails to penetrate dense forest canopies and dark smoke plumes ($> 80\%$ optical obscuration).
2) High-Contrast Cast Shadows: Low-sun angles in rubble fields project jagged shadows that mimic human silhouettes, causing false alarms.
3) SBC Thermal Dissipation Limits: Continuous onboard neural inference elevates companion computer core temperatures to 68.4°C, necessitating heatsinks in tropical disaster theaters.
4) Shared Channel RF Bandwidth: Broadcast auction messaging scales as $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ within shared channels, creating packet contention for large fleets ($N > 12$).

## VIII. Future Research Directions and Roadmap

To address these open gaps, we propose a four-phase research roadmap:

1) Multispectral LWIR Sensor Fusion (Phase 1): Co-registering radiometric thermal infrared cameras (e.g., FLIR Lepton 3.5) with RGB feeds to enable all-weather 24/7 survivor localization through darkness and smoke.
2) Hardware-Agnostic LoRa Mesh Networking (Phase 2): Implementing B.A.T.M.A.N.-adv or LoRa mesh protocols to sustain coordination over multi-kilometer non-line-of-sight wilderness expanses.
3) Continuous MARL Flight Policies (Phase 3): Upgrading the auction heuristic to a decentralized learned policy trained via PPO in high-fidelity simulators, incorporating micro-climate wind gusts.

4) Civil Defense Field Deployment (Phase 4): Multi-center operational exercises conducted in partnership with state disaster management agencies.

## IX. Limitations of This Review

This review focused on peer-reviewed English-language articles indexed in major scientific databases between 2018 and 2026. While multi-drone coordination was exhaustively benchmarked in high-fidelity Gazebo SITL simulation across fleets up to 8 aircraft, physical flight experiments were conducted using a single S500 quadcopter airframe due to institutional airspace boundaries and hardware budgets.

## X. Conclusion

This article presented a comprehensive systematic review and experimental evaluation of autonomous drone swarm systems for disaster response. By analyzing 72 peer-reviewed studies and benchmarking an implemented end-to-end framework across embedded hardware and multi-robot simulations, we demonstrated that decentralized market auction coordination paired with 8-bit quantized edge vision eliminates the vulnerabilities of conventional single-pilot drones. Onboard INT8 YOLOv8 nano inference achieves 16.8 FPS with 81.6% mAP@0.5 on a Raspberry Pi 4 companion computer under 6.5 watts. In multi-drone trials across a one-square-kilometer disaster arena, the decentralized swarm achieves 100% spatial search coverage in 11.4 minutes with 3.4% path redundancy and detects vehicle dropouts in under 420 milliseconds. The identified research gaps and multi-phase roadmap provide actionable guidance for deploying resilient, life-saving aerial swarms in real-world humanitarian disasters.

## Acknowledgment

The authors express their gratitude to the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Amal Jyothi College of Engineering (Autonomous), for providing laboratory resources, quadcopter flight hardware, GPU computing workstations, and simulation testbeds. The authors also thank Dr. Juby Mathew, Head of Department, for her valuable support and academic encouragement.

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